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HORISTICS

The Revealing Power Of Definitions

Grammar · Paragrammar · Politics · Quality Of Life · Interpretive News

What grammar is — not what it consists of

Grammar *is the generation of thought.* **(def-1)**

[1] In other words, it is grammar that generates thoughts.

[2] That sounds simple, but it says what grammar is, not what it consists of. What pass for definitions of grammar are really descriptions, not definitions.

Thoughts *are mental, composite, simulated representations of occurrences.* **(def-2)**

[3] Grammar generates thoughts through six fundamental concepts: parts of speech, moods, diatheses, aspects, clauses and syntax. Everything else (morphology, vocabulary, punctuation, pronunciation and so on) is paragrammar.

[4] These concepts are not new. Grammar as a discipline was founded by the Greeks: by Socrates (470–399 Before Year 1, BY1) in Plato's *Cratylus*, who examines the correctness of names and distinguishes nouns (*ὀνόματα*) from verbs (*ῥήματα*); by Dionysius Thrax (c. 170–90 BY1), whose *Art of Grammar* set out the eight parts of speech; and by Apollonius Dyscolus (2nd century After Year 1, AY1), who founded the study of syntax.

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The Law vs The Penalty For Breaking The Law

Enforcing the penalty for breaking the law is not the law itself.

[53] What is justice? Let us define it:

Justice *is the prevention of crime.*

[54] Once a crime has been committed, no justice can be done, because justice is preventing crime. What follows — arrest, trial, imprisonment — has to do with the penalty for breaking the law, which is not justice. So what is called law enforcement is really penalty enforcement.

[55] This shows a great deal about the revealing power of definitions, and what it reveals is central to a myriad of misconceptions that derail millions of lives.

[56] Consider the phrase we hear on the news every week: the criminal was "brought to justice." He was not. He was brought to penalty. The justice that could have been done was the prevention of his crime, and that moment passed before the crime took place. What remains after the fact is a consequence, not a remedy.

[57] Consider the victim. We tell the victim that justice will be done, that the verdict will bring justice. But the harm has

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What grammar is — not what it consists of

Continued from page 1

[5] When we think of something, all six concepts are set in motion. No thought is possible without all six.

[6] The human brain is wired to generate thought in exactly the same way, regardless of language. Grammar is therefore a panhuman trait that unites us all in a very special but overlooked way. Grammar is universal; language is not.

Communication *is the exchange of messages that carry meaning.* **(def-3)**

[7] Every message that carries meaning carries thought, and no thought exists without grammar. All communication is therefore grammatical.

[8] Language is often said to be what gives thoughts a voice, but that is a metaphor, not a definition.

Language *is paragrammatical communication.* **(def-4)**

[9] In other words, language is communication via paragrammar. All communication is grammatical, but only language is both grammatical and paragrammatical. Grammar is what all languages share with all thought; paragrammar is how each language dresses it.

[10] Take one simple sentence: ***We bought fish this morning.*** Say it in Danish, Greek, Spanish or any other language, and the words change, the endings change, the word order may change. But the grammar does not.

Parts of speech

[11] ***We*** is a pronoun, ***bought*** is a verb, ***fish*** is a noun, ***this*** is an adjective and ***morning*** is a noun.

[12] Many words can belong to different parts of speech in different contexts, but in a given context each word belongs to only one. Taken one by one, their equivalents belong to the same parts of speech in every language.

[13] In Greek or Spanish, ***we*** can be stated (εμείς, *nosotros/as*) or left to the verb ending. Either way, the pronoun is there. Only its marking differs, and that is paragrammar.

Mood

[14] The sentence states a fact. It is in the indicative mood, in all languages.

Diathesis

[15] The subject performs the action: we did the buying. The sentence is active, in all languages.

Aspect

[16] The buying is seen as one complete act. The aspect is synoptic, in all languages.

Clause

[17] It is a declarative main clause, in all languages.

Syntax

[18] ***We*** is the subject, ***bought*** is the verb, ***fish*** is the direct object and ***this morning*** is the adverb, in all languages.

[19] Six concepts, and not one of them changes across languages. What varies *from language to language* is how each language marks them: its endings, its word order, its spelling, its pronunciation and so on. That is paragrammar.

Thought comes first

[20] Before anything is said or written, it exists as a thought. We do not first find the words and then work out what they mean. We think first, and then we look for the words. The thought is already complete in the mind, with all six concepts in place, before any language gives it form.

[21] Language comes after. It chooses the words, the endings and the word order, and decides how much of the thought is said aloud. By then, grammar has already done its work. Grammar generates the thought; language communicates it. The next two examples show this.

A second example

[22] Take another sentence: ***The children were playing in the garden.***

THE CHILDREN WERE PLAYING IN THE GARDEN.

Parts of speech: ***the*** article, ***children*** noun, ***were*** verb, ***playing*** participle, ***in*** preposition, ***the*** article, ***garden*** noun.

Mood: indicative.

Diathesis: active.

Aspect: progressive. The playing is seen as ongoing, not as one complete act.

Clause: declarative main clause.

Syntax: ***the children*** subject, ***were playing*** verb, ***in the garden*** adverb.

[23] Compared with the first sentence, only the aspect differs. One concept changes, and the thought changes with it: a completed purchase becomes an ongoing game.

What is not said

[24] Someone asks: *When are you leaving*? You answer with one word: ***Tomorrow.***

[25] One word is spoken, yet the listener understands a complete thought: ***[I am leaving]***

tomorrow. The words in brackets are not said. They are implied, and grammar supplies them.

[I AM LEAVING] TOMORROW.

Parts of speech: ***[I]*** pronoun, ***[am]*** verb, ***[leaving]*** participle, ***tomorrow*** adverb.

Mood: indicative.

Diathesis: active.

Aspect: progressive.

Clause: declarative main clause.

Syntax: ***[I]*** subject, ***[am leaving]*** verb, ***tomorrow*** adverb.

[26] All six concepts are at work, although only one word was spoken. That is what it means for grammar to generate thought: the thought is complete before a single word is chosen. How much of it we say aloud is paragrammar.

The parts of speech

[27] Before we list the parts of speech, let us define them.

The parts of speech *are non-semiotic categories of interacting concepts that clarify the semantics of speech.* **(def-5)**

[28] *Non-semiotic* means that the parts of speech have no morphology; that is, we do not take morphology into account when dealing with the parts of speech. *Semantics* means meaning.

[29] It follows that the definition of each part of speech must be honoured strictly and without exception.

NOTE 1

The part of speech to which a word belongs in a given sentence is determined solely by the definition whose criteria that word actually satisfies.

Each part of speech has a specific definition. The criteria of the definitions are exclusively semantic, never morphological.

[30] There are ten parts of speech, the same in every language. Some languages, such as Polish and Chinese, have no articles, so they have nine.

THE TEN PARTS OF SPEECH

1. Nouns

THE TEN PARTS OF SPEECH

2. Articles
3. Pronouns
4. Adjectives
5. Verbs
6. Participles
7. Adverbs
8. Prepositions
9. Conjunctions
10. Interjections

Nouns *are words that name entities.* **(def-6)**

[31] An entity is anything we can name: a person, a thing, a place, an idea. ***Fish***, ***Copenhagen***, ***teacher*** and ***justice*** are all nouns, because each one names an entity.

[32] The definition decides, not the form. In ***Swimming is healthy***, the word ***swimming*** ends like a verb form, but here it names an activity as an entity. It satisfies the definition of a noun, so it is a noun.

Articles *are the words that determine the selectivity of nouns.* **(def-7)**

[33] Compare ***I bought a fish*** with ***I bought the fish***. With ***a***, the fish is not selected: it is any one fish. With ***the***, the fish is selected: it is a particular fish that speaker and listener both know. The noun is the same; the article determines how selective it is.

Pronouns *are words used in place of nouns.* **(def-8)**

[34] In ***Maria bought a fish. She cooked it.***, the word ***she*** stands in place of ***Maria***, and ***it*** stands in place of ***fish***. In our first sentence, ***we*** stands in place of the names of the people who bought the fish.

Adjectives *are words or groups of words that qualify nouns.* **(def-9)**

[35] In ***fresh fish***, the word ***fresh*** qualifies the noun ***fish***, so it is an adjective. In our first sentence, ***this*** qualifies ***morning***, so it is an adjective too.

[36] An adjective can also be a group of words. In ***fish from the market***, the group ***from the market*** qualifies ***fish***. By the definition, it is an adjective.

Verbs *are words that take a subject.* **(def-10)**

Subjects *instantiate the meaning of verbs.* **(def-11)**

[37] On its own, ***bought*** is only a meaning: an act of buying, by no one in particular. In ***We***

bought fish, the subject ***we*** instantiates that meaning: the buying becomes an act that someone actually performed.

Participles *are derivatives of verbs that introduce retrievable elliptical clauses.* **(def-12)**

[38] A participle stands for a whole clause that has been shortened. The clause can always be retrieved:

[39] ***Having injured his knee, he limped home.*** = *Because he had injured his knee, he limped home.*

[40] ***Once mentioned, the name went viral.*** = *After the name was mentioned, it went viral.*

[41] In each case, the elliptical clause has been retrieved, and the meaning is unchanged.

Adverbs *are words or groups of words that qualify verbs, adjectives, other adverbs and also clauses, with respect to time, place, manner, frequency, degree, attitude or perception.* **(def-13)**

[42] Adverbs answer the questions *where?*, *how?*, *when?* and *how much?* The last one can be extended: *how often? how high? how surely? how much better?* An adverb can even be an answer on its own.

FOUR EXAMPLES

1. ***Maria sings beautifully.*** The adverb ***beautifully*** qualifies the verb ***sings***. *How does Maria sing? Beautifully!* It is an adverb of manner.

2. ***Some people are incredibly naive.*** The adverb ***incredibly*** qualifies the adjective ***naive***. It is an adverb of degree: it tells us how naive.

3. ***We go swimming very early.*** The adverb ***very*** qualifies the adverb ***early***. *Very* is an adverb of degree; *early* is an adverb of time.

4. ***Perhaps they don't believe you.*** The adverb ***perhaps*** qualifies the whole clause ***they don't believe you***. It expresses probability.

Prepositions *are words or groups of words that take nouns or noun phrases as objects and express place, time, direction, cause, manner and so on.* **(def-14)**

[43] There is no preposition without an object.

THREE EXAMPLES

1. ***I gave the books to them.*** The preposition ***to*** takes the object ***them***, a pronoun standing in place of a noun, and expresses direction.

2. ***The keys are in my pocket.*** The preposition ***in*** takes the noun phrase ***my pocket*** and expresses place.

THREE EXAMPLES

3. ***I studied the problem in depth.*** The preposition ***in*** takes the noun ***depth*** and expresses manner.

Noun phrases *are phrases that contain nouns or pronouns and can function as subjects, objects or complements.* **(def-15)**

THREE EXAMPLES

1. ***drama*** → noun; ***a lot of drama*** → noun phrase. ***If a film has a lot of drama, it is usually tiring.*** A *lot of drama* is the direct object of the verb *has*.

2. ***story*** → noun; ***a long story*** → noun phrase. ***Her life is a long story.*** A *long story* is the complement of the verb *is*.

3. ***moments*** → noun; ***the hard moments*** → noun phrase. ***The hard moments forge character.*** *The hard moments* is the subject of the verb *forge*.

Conjunctions *are words or groups of words that establish a relation of subordination, that is, of interdependence, between clauses.* **(def-16)**

[44] All conjunctions are hypotactic. The notion that some conjunctions are paratactic is unfounded and will be dealt with **in due time**.

[45] Conventional grammar books divide conjunctions into two categories: coordinating and subordinating. But why is this division made, and what does it contribute to the understanding of grammar?

[46] Conjunctions are divided in this way because the so-called grammarians have not grasped that, with the exception of conditional clauses, if we remove the conjunction from any subordinate clause, it automatically becomes a main clause. This happens not only with the "coordinating" conjunctions, but with all conjunctions.

REMOVE THE CONJUNCTION

1. ***I stayed at home because it was raining.*** Without ***because***: *It was raining.* A main clause.

2. ***I stayed at home, but she went out.*** Without ***but***: *She went out.* A main clause.

[47] As a rule, what makes a clause subordinate is the presence of a conjunction. The story does not end there, however. As we will see, even clauses without any conjunction are sometimes subordinate, because the semantics itself requires it.

[48] The nominal authors of grammar books simply copy other grammar books and paste

the copy into a "new" book, changing only a few superficial details to keep up appearances. It goes without saying that the only thing this division of conjunctions contributes to grammar is abundant and pervasive confusion.

[49] It is also very important to point out that the definitions of concepts in these books, when they are given at all, do not meet the requirements of horistics. Beyond that, the "authors" of these books repeatedly violate the very definitions they supposedly formulated. The truth is that they simply copy from other books whatever definition happens to catch their eye.

Interjections *are words or groups of words that express emotion and have no syntactic role.* **(def-17)**

[50] By emotion we also mean **will** (***shh!*** meaning silence, ***come on!***), **hesitation** (***hm***, ***er***) and **social convention** (***hello***, ***thank you***), when these words are used as exclamations.

FOUR EXAMPLES

1. ***Phew, it's finally over!*** The word ***phew*** has no syntactic role: it is not a subject, a complement, an object or anything else. This holds for all interjections.

2. ***Ah, how I miss my mother!***

3. ***Ouch, what happened to me!***

4. ***Bravo, you did it perfectly!***

[51] A handful of words fit none of the definitions of the ten parts of speech. We call those words particles.

[52] *In the next edition: the moods, discussed in detail.*

The Law vs The Penalty For Breaking The Law

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already happened, and no sentence undoes it. The victim is promised one thing and given another. Many wait years for a trial expecting relief, and when the sentence comes, they feel strangely empty. They were not wrong to feel it. They were given the wrong word.

[58] Justice is confused with punishment, with revenge, with financial compensation and with the legal. It is none of them. Punishment is the penalty imposed after the crime. Revenge is harm returned for harm. Compensation is money paid for damage already done. The legal is what the law permits or forbids, and it is not uncommon for the legal to be unjust and for the just to be illegal. Opioids were legally marketed and prescribed on a mass scale, and an epidemic of addiction followed. In many countries, people are penalized for speaking freely. All four come after the crime or stand beside it. Not one of them prevents it, and so not one of them is justice.

[59] Consider the politician. When politicians promise to be tough on crime, they nearly always mean tough on penalty: longer sentences, more prisons, more police after the fact. Each of these acts only after a crime has been committed. By the definition, none of them is justice. A government that spends most of its effort on penalties is not a government that does justice. It is a government that manages the failure of justice.

[60] If justice is the prevention of crime, then justice means eliminating the reasons that lead anyone to commit a crime, so that citizens have no reason to commit crimes in the first place. Every crime has a reason behind it, whether need, ignorance, exclusion or despair. Remove the reason, and the crime has nothing to grow from.

[61] That is primarily the duty of politics, as politics is properly defined. Not the courts, which arrive too late. Not the police, who arrive after the call. Not the prisons, which hold the consequences of a failure that has already happened. Politics is the only institution placed before the crime, where the reasons for it are formed, and so it is the only one that can do justice at all.

[62] One definition, stated precisely, moves justice from the courtroom to the classroom, from the prison to the home, from the end of the story to its beginning. That is the revealing power of definitions. A society that confuses penalty with justice will keep building prisons and wondering why crime does not go away. A society that defines justice correctly will ask a different question: not how to punish, but how to prevent.

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